Haunted Landlord

Complete Design and Virality Plan for a Browser Idle Game

1. Concept

You inherit a creaky old house. Ghosts move in and pay you rent. You renovate rooms to attract nastier, richer ghosts, hire help, and eventually expand to a haunted street, a haunted town, and beyond. When progress slows, you perform an **Exorcism** (prestige): the house resets, but you keep a permanent spooky multiplier and unlock new content.

One-line pitch: "Your tenants are dead, your rent is not."
Tone: funny-spooky, never gory. Think cozy Halloween with a dry sense of humor, so it is safe to share with anyone.

2. Core Gameplay Loop

- **Click** the front door or a ghost to collect Rent (the main currency).
- **Spend Rent** on room upgrades, furniture, and decor that attract specific ghost types.
- **Ghosts pay automatically** each second. Better ghosts pay more and have quirks.
- **Random events** (poltergeist tantrum, tenant dispute, ghost party) give short bonuses or tradeoffs.
- **Exorcism (prestige)** converts total rent earned into Spectral Essence, a permanent multiplier and unlock currency.

3. Core Viral Requirements (Detailed)

A 10-second hook

- First click makes a coin pop and a ghost named "Gary" drift in with a one-line joke.
- First upgrade is affordable within about 10 seconds so the player instantly feels progress.
- Satisfying feedback: coin sounds, screen shake on big purchases, floating numbers.

Offline progress

- Ghosts keep paying while the tab is closed, with a sensible cap (for example 8 to 12 hours) so returning feels rewarding.
- Welcome-back screen: "The ghosts haunted while you slept" with rent earned and a funny ghost anecdote.
- Optional browser notification when the rent vault is full (opt-in only).

Shareable moments

- Exorcism result card: house name, total rent, spookiest tenant, prestige count, designed to look good as a screenshot.
- Auto-generated house names ("Dread Manor of Gary", "Sir Boo-Boo's Bed and Breakfast").
- One-tap Share or Copy Image button, plus a short link back to the game.

Secrets

- Hidden room that unlocks only if you leave the game idle for 5 minutes.
- Midnight ghost that appears only between 12:00 and 1:00 AM local time.
- Cursed upgrades that look like bad deals but secretly pay off big.
- Secret achievements with cryptic hints to fuel Reddit and Discord theory threads.

Global element

- Community Haunting Meter: all players' rent fills a shared bar that unlocks a limited-time event ghost for everyone.
- Weekly leaderboard for Best Haunted House, resettable so new players can compete.
- "Ghosts summoned worldwide" counter on the title screen.

Short sessions, deep late game

- First session of 3 to 5 minutes gives a complete mini-loop with a first prestige tease.
- New layers revealed over days and weeks: new floors, ghost families, rival landlords, town expansion.
- Each layer introduces one new mechanic rather than overwhelming the player.

Zero friction

- No login, no download, no ads before play. Autosave to the browser.
- Loads in about 2 seconds; keep the first load under 2 MB if possible.
- Mobile-first controls with large tap targets; works on both portrait and landscape.

4. Extra Features That Increase Popularity

These go beyond the basics and target the specific behaviors that make idle games spread and retain players.

Feature	Why it helps
Collectible Ghost Codex	A gallery of 60+ ghosts, each with a name, personality, and joke bio. Collection completion drives long-term play and screenshots of rare finds.
Ghost personalities and rivalries	Some ghosts dislike each other (the Victorian ghost hates the Disco ghost). Placing them in the same room has funny consequences, giving puzzle-lite strategy.
Daily Haunting and streaks	A small daily bonus with an escalating streak. Keeps players returning without punishing missed days (streak freezes).
Seasonal events	Halloween, Friday the 13th, Christmas (ghost of Christmas past rent), Valentine's (lovesick ghosts). Each brings limited-time ghosts and decor.
House customization	Wallpaper, furniture, lighting, and exterior skins. Players love showing off their house, which makes the share image more personal.
Rival Landlords	Funny NPC competitors who "poach" ghosts. Adds light tension and story without needing multiplayer.
Visit a friend's house	Shareable house code lets others view a read-only version of your house. Free social loop without complex multiplayer.
Ghost Hunter mini-event	Every few minutes a ghost hunter shows up. Tap quickly to defend your tenants for a bonus. Adds active-play moments to an idle game.
Sound and music	Spooky-cozy soundtrack, satisfying coin and chime sounds, and a mute toggle. Audio makes the game feel premium.
Achievements with rewards	100+ achievements, many funny. Each gives a small permanent bonus so they feel meaningful.
Quality-of-life	Buy max, auto-buy unlocks after prestige, number formatting options, dark and light themes, and a clear stats page.
Easter eggs and meta humor	Clicking the moon, the cat, or the chimney triggers jokes. Developer notes from "the ghost of the programmer".
Discord and subreddit hooks	In-game link to a community with an official suggestions channel. Credit players whose ideas get added.
Fair, friendly monetization	Keep it fully playable free. Optional cosmetic skins or a one-time supporter pack. Avoid pay-to-win and pushy ads, which kill word of mouth.

5. Progression Plan

Time	What unlocks	Purpose
0 to 10 min	One room, first ghosts, first upgrades	Hook and instant progress
10 to 60 min	Second room, ghost types, first random events	Variety and choices
1 to 3 hours	Basement and attic, ghost rivalries, first Exorcism	Prestige discovery

Time	What unlocks	Purpose
Day 2 to 7	Spectral Essence shop, auto-buy, Ghost Codex goals	Return habit
Week 2 to 4	Haunted street, rival landlords, seasonal events	Scale and rivalry
Month 2+	Haunted town, second prestige layer (Cursed Deeds), community meter	Long-term depth

6. Prestige System: The Exorcism

- First Exorcism offered around the 1 to 2 hour mark, with a clear preview of the Spectral Essence you will earn.
- Essence gives a permanent rent multiplier plus spendable unlocks (new ghost families, automation, cosmetic perks).
- Funny exorcism animation with a short skip option, so repeat prestiges never feel slow.
- Second-layer prestige, **Cursed Deeds**, resets Essence in exchange for a bigger multiplier and new rules, giving long-term depth.

7. Sample Ghost Roster

Ghost	Rarity	Quirk
Gary	Common	Forgot he is dead. Pays rent in loose change.
Lady Beatrix	Uncommon	Victorian; pays more in fancy rooms, hates loud ghosts.
Disco Dan	Uncommon	Boosts nearby ghosts' rent but annoys Victorians.
The Accountant	Rare	Increases offline earnings by auditing the books.
Poltergeist Pete	Rare	Random chaos: big payout or a broken lamp.
Midnight Mabel	Secret	Only appears 12 to 1 AM local time.
The Landlord's Landlord	Legendary	Late game boss tenant who raises everyone's rent.

8. Art, UX, and Tone

- **Art style:** bold, simple, rounded cartoon ghosts with strong silhouettes that read well as thumbnails and GIFs.
- **Palette:** deep purples and teals with warm window glows for a cozy-spooky look.
- **Animation:** every ghost idles with a small unique motion; the house reacts to purchases.
- **UI:** single main screen with the house on top and upgrade lists below; no clutter or nested menus early on.
- **Writing:** short, punchy jokes; every ghost, upgrade, and achievement has a line of flavor text.

9. Launch and Marketing Plan

- **Thumbnail and short clips:** record 10 to 15 second GIFs of funny ghost moments for Reddit, X, and TikTok.

- **Where to post:** r/incremental_games, r/WebGames, r/IndieGaming, itch.io, and Newgrounds; read each community's self-promo rules first.
- **Timing:** aim to go live 2 to 3 weeks before Halloween so the seasonal spike carries it.
- **Playtest first:** get 10 to 20 players for feedback on the first 10 minutes before public launch.
- **Respond fast:** reply to early comments and patch bugs quickly; active developers get recommended more.
- **Weekly updates:** small content drops with patch notes keep the community talking.

10. Technical Notes

- Plain HTML, CSS, and JavaScript or a light framework; no heavy engine needed.
- Use a big-number library or careful number formatting for late-game values.
- Save to localStorage with versioned save data and export/import save codes.
- Compute offline progress from timestamps rather than running timers.
- Host cheaply on Cloudflare Pages, Netlify, or itch.io for fast global loading.
- Track light, privacy-friendly analytics to see where players drop off in the first 10 minutes.

11. MVP Checklist

- Click-to-earn, 5 ghost types, 4 rooms, 20 upgrades
- Offline progress with welcome-back screen
- First Exorcism with Spectral Essence shop
- Share card for prestige results
- 10 achievements and 2 hidden secrets
- Sound toggle, mobile layout, and autosave
- Community Haunting Meter (simple version)

Success tip: Ship small, listen to players, and add one delightful thing every week. Idle games grow through community and steady updates.

12. Adult Appeal Layer

Adults are a huge part of the idle and incremental audience. The goal is humor and relatability rather than extra darkness, so the game stays friendly to everyone while giving grown-ups more to enjoy.

Appeal	How to build it
Dry, satirical writing	Landlord life made relatable: ghosts dispute rent hikes, file maintenance requests about their own haunting, and lodge noise complaints against each other. Think *What We Do in the Shadows* meets property management.
Adult-world humor	Mortgages, HOA rules, lease clauses, property taxes, security deposits, and a former tenant who owes back rent. Flavor text should work on two levels.
Real strategy depth	Ghost synergies and rivalries, room layouts that matter, and tradeoffs between short-term rent and long-term prestige gains. Adults enjoy optimizing and theorycrafting.
Respect for their time	Generous offline progress, no energy timers, no pushy ads, and a one-time supporter pack instead of aggressive monetization. This is the biggest trust builder.
Cozy, low-stress play	A game that can stay open at work or be played before bed. Add a calm mode and soothing sound design.
Nostalgia and pop-culture nods	Ghosts inspired by eras (80s, 90s, disco, Victorian) and subtle movie and TV references.
Mild dark humor, not gore	A slightly macabre tone (funny deaths, bureaucratic afterlife) feels sophisticated without being grim.
Landlord's Ledger	A stats page with graphs, income breakdowns, and efficiency numbers for the incremental-game crowd, which skews adult.
Shareable adult humor	Prestige cards styled as fake eviction notices, lease agreements, or a Landlord of the Year plaque that people post for a laugh.

Sample Adult-Oriented Ghost Tenants

Ghost	Rarity	Quirk
Gary from Accounting	Common	Died at his desk, still files expense reports. Slightly boosts offline earnings.
Karen the Unliving	Uncommon	Demands to speak to the manager. Pays well but causes random complaint events.
The HOA Spirit	Rare	Fines other ghosts for violations. Reduces chaos events, raises rent.
Chad, Crypto Ghost	Rare	Rent income swings wildly: huge payouts or nothing at all.
Dead Landlord Dolores	Legendary	Your predecessor. Takes a cut of your rent but unlocks late-game perks.

Sample Jokes and Flavor Text

- Upgrade: **Creaky Floorboards** - "Free ambiance. Tenants call it a safety hazard."
- Upgrade: **Security Deposit** - "Non-refundable, because they are not leaving."
- Event: **Noise Complaint** - "Disco Dan has been rehearsing at 3 AM. Again."

- Achievement: **Passive Income** - "Earn rent for 24 hours without clicking."
- Prestige card: **NOTICE OF EXORCISM** - "You have 30 days to vacate the afterlife."

Balance tip: Keep jokes clever and mild so the game stays shareable and safe for all ages. Adult appeal should come from wit and depth, not edgy content.